

COMMUNICATIVE ENGLISH

Unit-III: Secretarial Skills

Comprehensive Study Notes

Topic 1: Effective Communication

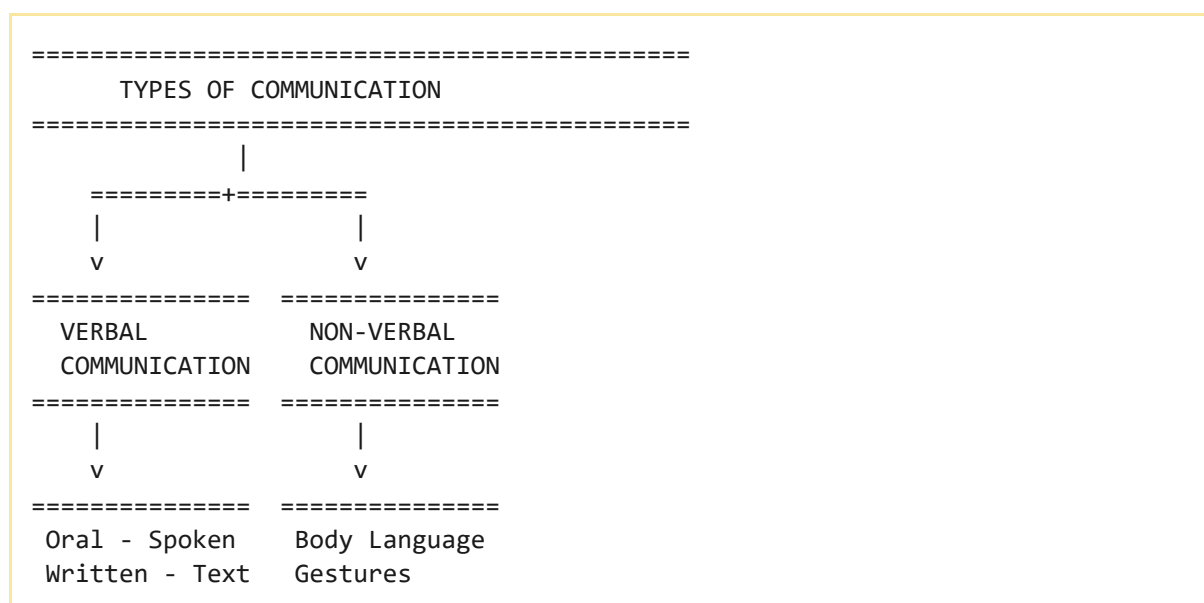
1.1 What is Effective Communication?

Effective communication is the process of **exchanging information, ideas, and feelings** in a way that the message is **clearly understood** by the receiver. It is the foundation of all professional interactions and secretarial work.

1.2 Importance of Effective Communication

Reason	Description
Clear Understanding	Ensures messages are understood correctly
Professional Image	Reflects positively on the organization
Efficiency	Saves time and prevents misunderstandings
Relationship Building	Builds trust and rapport with colleagues and clients
Decision Making	Provides accurate information for decisions
Conflict Resolution	Helps resolve misunderstandings and disputes

1.3 Types of Communication



Facial Expressions
Eye Contact

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1.4 Barriers to Effective Communication

Barrier	Description	Example
Language Barrier	Different languages or vocabulary	Using technical jargon with a non-technical person
Cultural Barrier	Different cultural backgrounds	Gestures that mean different things in different cultures
Psychological Barrier	Emotional or mental state	Stress, anxiety, or anger affecting communication
Physical Barrier	Environmental factors	Noise, distance, or poor technology
Perceptual Barrier	Different interpretations	Assuming the listener understands without checking
Information Overload	Too much information	Giving too many details at once

Topic 2: Listening Skills

2.1 Importance of Listening

Listening is a **critical skill** for secretaries and professionals. It ensures that instructions, requests, and information are accurately understood.

2.2 Types of Listening

Type	Description
Critical Listening	Evaluating and judging the message
Comprehensive Listening	Understanding the message fully
Dialogic Listening	Interactive, two-way listening
Empathic Listening	Understanding the speaker's feelings
Informational Listening	Gathering information

2.3 Tips for Effective Listening

Tip	Description
Pay Attention	Focus on the speaker completely
Avoid Interrupting	Let the speaker finish before responding
Show Interest	Use non-verbal cues like nodding
Ask Clarifying Questions	Ensure understanding
Take Notes	Record important information
Provide Feedback	Summarize to confirm understanding

Topic 3: Feedback Skills

3.1 What is Feedback?

Feedback is the **response or reaction** given to a message or performance. It helps improve communication and work quality.

3.2 Types of Feedback

Type	Description	Example
Positive Feedback	Encouraging and reinforcing	"You did excellent work on the report."
Negative Feedback	Pointing out areas for improvement	"The report needs more details in the budget section."
Constructive Feedback	Specific and helpful criticism	"Try to include more data analysis in the report."
Descriptive Feedback	Describing what was observed	"I noticed you completed the task ahead of schedule."

3.3 Tips for Giving Feedback

Tip	Description
Be Specific	Give concrete examples
Be Timely	Give feedback soon after the event
Be Respectful	Use a polite and professional tone
Focus on Behavior	Not on the person's character
Offer Solutions	Suggest ways to improve
Encourage Dialogue	Allow the receiver to respond

Topic 4: Telephone Handling

4.1 Importance of Telephone Skills

A secretary is often the **first point of contact** for an organization. Effective telephone handling creates a positive impression and ensures smooth communication.

4.2 Rules for Handling Telephone Calls

Rule	Description
Answer Promptly	Answer within 2–3 rings
Identify Yourself	State your name and organization
Speak Clearly	Use a pleasant and professional tone
Listen Actively	Pay full attention to the caller
Take Messages	Record details accurately
Return Calls	Respond to missed calls promptly

4.3 Taking Telephone Messages

Information	Description
Caller's Name	Full name and organization
Phone Number	Contact number
Date and Time	When the call was received
Purpose	Reason for the call
Action Required	What needs to be done

Message Taker

Name of the person who took the message

4.4 Sample Telephone Message Format

TELEPHONE MESSAGE

Date: 15th July 2026

Time: 10:30 AM

To: Mr. Rahul Sharma

From: Ms. Priya Singh

Organization: ABC Corporation

Phone: 98765 43210

Message: Please call back regarding the meeting
scheduled for tomorrow.

Action Required: Return call

Message Taken By: Neha

Topic 5: Attending Meetings

5.1 Role of a Secretary in Meetings

A secretary plays a crucial role in the success of a meeting, from preparation to follow-up.

5.2 Responsibilities Before the Meeting

Task	Description
Prepare Agenda	List of items to be discussed
Send Invitations	Notify participants about the meeting
Book Venue	Reserve the meeting room
Arrange Materials	Prepare documents and presentations
Set Up Equipment	Ensure technology is working

5.3 Responsibilities During the Meeting

Task	Description
Welcome Participants	Greet attendees
Take Minutes	Record discussions and decisions
Manage Time	Keep the meeting on schedule
Take Notes	Document key points
Assist the Chairperson	Provide support as needed

5.4 Responsibilities After the Meeting

Task	Description
Write Minutes	Prepare the final minutes
Distribute Minutes	Send minutes to all participants
Follow Up	Track action items
File Documents	Organize meeting records

Topic 6: Preparing Agenda

6.1 What is an Agenda?

An agenda is a **list of items** to be discussed during a meeting. It helps the meeting stay focused and organized.

6.2 Structure of an Agenda

Component	Description
Header	Organization name, meeting type, date, time, venue
Title	"AGENDA"
List of Items	Numbered or bulleted list of topics
Time Allocation	Suggested time for each item
Additional Items	"Any other matter" section

6.3 Sample Agenda

XYZ COLLEGE
ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
AGENDA

Date: 25th July 2026 Time: 10:00 AM
Venue: Conference Hall

AGENDA

- | | |
|---|----------|
| 1. Reading and approval of previous minutes | (5 min) |
| 2. Progress report on various activities | (10 min) |
| 3. Discussion on budget allocation | (15 min) |
| 4. Planning for upcoming events | (10 min) |
| 5. Any other matter with permission | (5 min) |
| 6. Vote of thanks | (2 min) |

Total Time: 47 minutes

--- End of Agenda ---

Topic 7: Writing Minutes

7.1 What are Minutes?

Minutes are the **official written record** of a meeting. They document what was discussed, decisions made, and actions to be taken.

7.2 Structure of Minutes

Component	Description
Header	Organization, meeting type, date, time, venue
Attendees	List of present and absent members
Approval of Previous Minutes	Confirmation of previous minutes
Discussion Points	Summary of each agenda item
Decisions	Conclusions reached
Action Items	Tasks assigned to individuals
Next Meeting	Date and time of next meeting
Signature	Chairperson and Secretary

7.3 Sample Minutes

XYZ COLLEGE
MINUTES OF ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

Date: 25th July 2026 Time: 10:00 AM
Venue: Conference Hall

Attendees:

1. Dr. Suresh Kumar (Chairperson)
2. Ms. Priya Singh (Secretary)
3. Mr. Amit Verma (Member)
4. Ms. Neha Sharma (Member)

Item 1: Approval of Previous Minutes

The minutes of the previous meeting were read and approved.

Item 2: Progress Report

Various activities were reviewed. The progress is satisfactory.

Item 3: Budget Allocation

The budget for the next quarter was discussed and approved.

Item 4: Upcoming Events

Plans for the Annual Day celebration were discussed.

Action Items:

S.No.	Task	Responsible	Deadline
1	Prepare budget report	Mr. Verma	30th July
2	Book venue for Annual Day	Ms. Sharma	20th July

Next Meeting: 15th August 2026

--- Minutes Approved ---

Chairperson: Dr. Suresh Kumar

Secretary: Ms. Priya Singh

Topic 8: Handling Problem Situations

8.1 Common Problem Situations

Situation	Description
Difficult Callers	Angry or upset callers
Scheduling Conflicts	Overlapping appointments
Last-Minute Changes	Unexpected cancellations
Confidential Information	Handling sensitive data
Technical Issues	Equipment failures during meetings

8.2 Tips for Handling Problem Situations

Tip	Description
Stay Calm	Maintain composure
Listen Carefully	Understand the problem fully
Be Professional	Respond politely and professionally
Offer Solutions	Suggest practical solutions
Follow Up	Ensure the issue is resolved
Report Issues	Inform the appropriate person

8.3 Dealing with Difficult Callers

Step	Description
1. Stay Calm	Keep a professional tone

2. Listen	Let them express their concern
3. Empathize	Show understanding
4. Apologize	If appropriate, apologize for the inconvenience
5. Offer Solutions	Suggest ways to resolve the issue
6. Take Action	Follow through on promises
7. Follow Up	Ensure satisfaction

Topic 9: Control of Voice and Phonetics

9.1 Importance of Voice Control

Voice control is essential for secretaries and professionals who need to communicate clearly and effectively over the phone and in person.

9.2 Elements of Voice Control

Element	Description
Volume	Speaking at the right loudness
Pitch	Using an appropriate tone
Pace	Speaking at a comfortable speed
Clarity	Pronouncing words clearly
Modulation	Varying tone to avoid monotony
Articulation	Enunciating words properly

9.3 Tips for Voice Control

Tip	Description
Breathe Properly	Use proper breathing techniques
Practice	Read aloud to improve clarity
Record Yourself	Listen and improve
Slow Down	Avoid speaking too fast
Use Pauses	Pause for effect and clarity

Questions

Short Answer Questions (2–5 Marks)

1. What is effective communication?
2. What are the types of communication?
3. What is the role of a secretary in a meeting?
4. What is an agenda? What does it contain?
5. What are minutes? Why are they important?
6. What are telephone etiquette rules?
7. What are the barriers to effective communication?
8. What is the importance of listening skills?
9. What is constructive feedback?
10. How should a secretary handle a difficult caller?

Long Answer Questions (10 Marks)

1. Explain effective communication and its importance in a secretary's role.
2. What is the role of a secretary before, during, and after a meeting?
3. Explain the steps for preparing an agenda and writing minutes.
4. Discuss the barriers to effective communication and how to overcome them.
5. Explain telephone handling skills for a secretary.
6. How should a secretary handle problem situations?

Objective Questions (1 Mark)

1. The first point of contact in an organization is usually:
(a) Manager (b) Secretary (c) CEO (d) Employee
Answer: (b)
2. Minutes are written record of:
(a) A letter (b) A meeting (c) A report (d) A complaint

Answer: (b)

3. An agenda is prepared before:

- (a) A letter (b) A meeting (c) A report (d) A complaint

Answer: (b)

4. Effective communication requires:

- (a) Clear message (b) Understanding (c) Feedback (d) All of the above

Answer: (d)

5. A good secretary should have:

- (a) Communication skills (b) Organizational skills (c) Both (d) None

Answer: (c)

Quick Revision

Secretarial Skills Summary

Secretarial Skills

- |
- +-- Effective Communication
 - | +-- Verbal (Oral/Written)
 - | +-- Non-verbal (Body Language)
 - |
- +-- Listening Skills
 - | +-- Critical
 - | +-- Comprehensive
 - | +-- Empathic
 - | +-- Informational
 - |
- +-- Feedback Skills
 - | +-- Positive
 - | +-- Negative
 - | +-- Constructive
 - |
- +-- Telephone Handling
 - | +-- Answering
 - | +-- Taking Messages
 - | +-- Returning Calls
 - |
- +-- Meeting Skills
 - | +-- Agenda Preparation
 - | +-- Minutes Writing
 - | +-- Follow-up
 - |
- +-- Problem Handling
 - +-- Difficult Callers
 - +-- Scheduling Conflicts
 - +-- Technical Issues

Key Formulas

Concept	Key Point
Effective Communication	Clear message + Understanding + Feedback
Meeting Success	Agenda + Minutes + Follow-up
Telephone Etiquette	Professional + Polite + Prompt

Feedback

Specific + Timely + Respectful

End of Unit-III Notes